

motivational

DIRECTOR'S TREATMENT
BY RICCARDO FUSETTI

.....logline.

Life coach Fitzroy Cunningham's self-assurance shatters when his ex-wife calls him before his biggest convention yet, sending him spiraling into a surreal vortex of anxiety and self-doubt.

.the story.....

The scene opens with Fitzroy - maybe 40, slick hair, goatee, three-piece suit, pocket square, showy watch, confident grin, a true showman - he is filming a video on his phone, facing the camera, speaking to his followers about the personal growth event that is about to take place shortly. It's the biggest event of the community yet and he is so thankful to all of the people who showed up.

Just as Fitzroy is about to wrap up filming the video, his phone starts ringing with a call from his ex-wife.

In a full shot, we see Fitzroy in his dressing room, looking vexed as he answers the call - the warmth and composure he displayed on the recording for his followers are now gone.

His ex-wife is requesting for him to retrieve their son from a football practice session as she can no longer do it due to an unexpected occurrence.

Fitzroy declines and starts arguing with her - he can barely hear what she is saying as there is bad reception in the room - he says he can't do it just now but he'll figure something out. It's really hot in the room and Fitzroy is staring to sweat slightly.

From outside the room, we can hear the loud sound of a drill on the wall and the heavy bass of a techno song.

Visibly frustrated, he calls his current girlfriend to ask her to pick up his son for him - she clearly isn't going to do it.

As he argues on the phone we hear a knock on the door - it's his agent Ana, she's here to make sure he's ready as the show starts in 5.

.the story. cont'd.....

With a big, calming smile, Fitzroy says he has to take this call but he will be right with her in a minute. He asks her to make sure his beetroot shot is ready before the show.

The noise they had heard earlier is coming from the repairman, who is fixing the AC unit outside the changing room. He is blasting music from a portable speaker, and it doesn't seem like he is trying very hard.

Fitzroy's ex-wife calls again and insists that he pick up their son. He says he can't do it and hangs up abruptly.

He walks with Ana down the long, narrow corridors of the venue, going over the program for the evening. The plan is for him to wait behind the big curtains of the main stage. Ana will introduce him, and as soon as she calls his name, he'll come in triumphantly. Ana tells him to get in position behind the curtain, and she'll meet him there

We follow Fitzroy as he navigates the maze of corridors, his discomfort growing with every unanswered vibration of his phone. He tries to orient himself by following the repairman's music coming from the distance but every corner seems to take him to completely different locations, he goes through several rooms that don't look like they belong in the venue he's in: he's completely lost. He bumps into the repairman twice in completely different locations - this place doesn't seem

to make any sense. The phone keeps ringing but he doesn't seem to even acknowledge the fact.

Ana appears out of nowhere and rushes Fitzroy towards the stage. As they walk, she informs him that the PA system is having issues and they might not be able to play the intro music. This news causes Fitzroy to completely lose it. He demands that Ana fix the problem immediately.

Fitzroy rages through the maze of corridors, his anger building with every step. He is lost, his phone is ringing. He is about to lose it when he sees it: a poster of himself, smiling and confident.

Fitzroy stops in his tracks and stares at the poster. He takes a few deep breaths and the chaos around him begins to fade. He can feel his anger slipping away, replaced by a sense of calm. He collects himself and walks towards the stage, ready to perform.





the story. cont'd.....

Fitzroy turns a corner and collides with the stagehand, spilling the beetroot shot on his jacket. He curses and storms back to his changing room, his phone buzzing furiously.

Ana chases after him, trying to calm him down, but he's out of control. She finally loses her temper and tells him to get his act together.

He snaps out of it, his self-assurance seemingly restored, he rolls up his sleeves and proceeds to walk towards the stage. The corridor is now a straight line guided by curtains with no obstacles in front of him.

Fitzroy waits behind the curtains, the restless crowd audible. Ana's voice booms through the speakers, introducing him. Fitzroy is silently mouthing Ana's words

exactly as they are spoken. Just as he is called on stage, we hear a strong buzz from his phone, he hesitates for a fraction of a second.

Cheesy triumphant music begins playing - the crowd is cheering - cut to title card.

.the maze.....

We are looking to craft a 10/15 minute short film that starts realistic but quickly and turns surreal.

We are going to treat the corridors as a real character and as our main device to portray Fitzroy's state of mind. They are an ever changing, confusing maze, never taking you where you thought they would. Fitzroy will try to navigate these nonsensical narrow corridors where the rules of time and space are slightly bended, much to the confusion of our main character.

To further enhance the surreal nature of the corridors, we will dress them and light them slightly differently each time Fitzroy passes through them, making the same space feel unfamiliar as the film progresses, mirroring Fitzroy's lack of control of the situation. He will turn a corner only to end up where he started, meeting the same person twice in row in ways that are not possible in real life.

Time is also slippery, Ana constantly reminds Fitzroy that the show starts in 5 min-

utes, increasing the sense of urgency and making us feel a lack of progress at the same time.

Visually, the corridors should be shabby, with peeling paint, flickering fluorescent lights, and scuffed flooring. The more diverse they look the better, ideally we would have plenty of staircases and different looking rooms.

The claustrophobic atmosphere will amplify the tension and sense of entrapment felt by Fitzroy.

Radiohead's music video for Daydreaming is a good reference of the surreal nonsensical corridor-maze we want to portray, although on a much larger scale.

Another interesting visual cue for the lack of progress is this reference Dolly-zoom shot. (Second reference on this slide) the character is walking but he doesn't seem to be moving much. It would be interesting to try and experiment with these kind of effects.



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Treatment by
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.Fitzroy Cunningham.....

Stage name: Fitzroy Cunningham
Real name: Paul Costa
Age: maybe 40
Appearance: Slick long hair, three-piece suit, pocket square, showy watch, expensive shoes, skin coloured headset.
Relationship status: Divorced - one daughter - Currently in a relationship.

Personality: Confident, charismatic, showy, vain, easily angered, prone to outbursts.

He defines himself as: Entrepreneur, Author, Teacher, Trainer, Speaker, Father.

Backstory: Only son of middle class Italian immigrants in London, although during his talks he pretends to have a working class background.

When he was 21, he quit his Marketing and Communication degree to start a series of unsuccessful start-ups.
At 26, he discovers motivational speaker Tony Robbins, attends a couple of his events in the US, sees the potential in coaching and decides to try his hand at it.

After years of hustling, he is finally establishing himself as a household name in the UK life coaching and Network Marketing scene. He has just released a book and regularly tours the country with his personal growth events.

His cocky persona starkly clashes with his mood swings and his tendency to avoid confronting issues in real-life.





.....quirks.

- .He constantly says to "write it down"
- .Subtle but frequent god mentions
- .Body language: Constant movement - he's never still
- .Constant quotes - politicians, sportspeople - religious figures
- .It's all about the people NEVER about the money

.quotes.....

"Give yourself a grade"

"If there were no ambitious people, who would the non-ambitious work for?"

"The ones who think small think about revenue, and the ones who think big think about people."

"Stupid people await to suffer, smart people learn by inspiration."

"I'm paying somebody to tell me the mistakes they made so that I can learn from them and I save on life, the most precious thing we have."

"Tell me, Tell me about yourself, what are your projects, your dreams, your future?"

Tell me, what makes your heart beat? What makes your heart ache? Why would you start a new project today? What are you really looking for? When you go to bed at night, what are your prayers for? When you wake up in the morning, what are you thankful for?"

"There are a lot of people who are so poor that all they have is money"

"We're not happy or sad according to where we are, we are happy or sad according to where we're going."

"There are no people with no talent, there are only people with no goals."



.casting ideas.....

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We are going for a nuanced approach to Fitzroy’s character. We want to paint the picture of a complex, flawed and dislikeable character.

At no point he should feel like a simple caricature.

His display of rage should never be on the nose. We want to see him wanting to erupt, but always trying his best to stick to his positive persona.

.secondary characters.....

.ANA .AGENT

Despite her professional and courteous demeanour, she despises working for Fitzroy and his unpredictable behaviour. She initially tiptoes around Fitzroy to avoid any potential issues that could arise from his volatile temperament but lashes out at him to make him snap out of his breakdown. This is not out of care but simply to get her job done.

.THE REPAIRMAN

Minor character, they are repairing the AC unit just outside Fitzroy's changing room. Constantly drilling and banging on the wall. Moody young guy, not very competent. He's there because he has to.

.STAGE HAND

Very minor character, spills drink on Fitzroy.

.LISA. EX-WIFE

We never actually see or hear her on the phone, we understand the context of the phone conversation purely on Fitzroy's answers.

.EMMA .GIRLFRIEND

Just like Ex-wife, we never see or hear her.

She is in a shallow relationship with Fitzroy, they met recently and things are not going great. They both seem barely interested in each other.

.locations.....

.CORRIDORS

See page.6

.BEHIND THE CURTAINS

The concluding scene will be situated just before the grand stage curtains, with the audience located on the other side remaining unseen, only their voices audible.

.CHANGING ROOM

Full of character, old, dodgy, and messy. The primary source of illumination will be a large makeup mirror surrounded by light bulbs.



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.cinematography.movement.....

To fully immerse the audience in Fitzroy's experience and convey his feeling of losing control, the film will use hand-held shots with mid-telephoto lenses, creating a claustrophobic but naturalistic style.

This will compress the space around Fitzroy and emphasize his wavering resolve, while allowing the camera to focus tightly on him.

The framing will be raw and free-flowing, with dramatic camera movements reflecting Fitzroy's emotional breakdown. We will allow the camera to find the frame as the action unfolds and we will prioritize long takes over coverage.



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.....cinematography.lighting.

We are going for a high contrast ratio, tungsten practicals will be our main source of illumination, giving our actors the freedom to pace around the set. We will allow our image to fall into darkness and silhouette our characters.

.music.sound design.....

On top of the cinematography techniques discussed on **page.15**, the sound scape will be crucial to portray Fitzroy's state of mind.

Chaotic sound elements will constantly be very present in the mix and audible at all times: his phone buzzing, a pipe leaking, loud diagetic music coming from the Handyman's speaker, floors creaking.

A crucial element of the sound design will be the **buzzing** of his phone. We will introduced early on as the source of his anxiety and it's a clear signifier of his inability to deal with minor problems. The buzzing will be extremely loud during the moments of peak stress and disappear in the final section right before the very end, where it will be brought back to shake his resolve right before he has to walk on stage.

The music coming from the Handyman's speaker will heighten Fitzroy sense of confusion as he is navigating through the corridors. It will appear and disappear and come from different directions from where our character (and us) are expecting it to be. Giving us a fake point of reference and further messing with our sense of direction in the maze-corridors.

Dialogue scenes will be unorderedly as well, we will have our actors speak on top of each other, constantly interrupting the other person.

Shiva Baby Soundtrack - [LISTEN HERE](#)

Uncut Gems Soundtrack - [LISTEN HERE](#)



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The above Trailers are a great reference for music but also for mood, general pacing, camera movement and framing.

.....director's statement.

This film will explore the moments leading up to a major event, focusing on the anticipation and in-between moments. The show is always “five minutes away,” always approaching but never happening within the film’s runtime.

The goal of this film is to portray a man desperately trying to be in control of his chaotic life. A man who wants, and simultaneously claims to have, answers in a world full of unanswered questions.

Throughout the film, the audience will witness the man’s struggle to maintain his resolve, as his confidence wavers and he chooses to evade his problems. The persistent ringing of his phone serves as a constant reminder of his inability to cope with even minor inconveniences, as he cannot bring himself to turn it off.

The man’s lack of control is further amplified by the maze-like corridors that seem to lead him in circles. These corridors contribute to the film’s tense and claustrophobic atmosphere. The buzzing of his phone heightens the urgency of his situation and reflects his unstable mental state.

The audience will observe the man’s lack of authority and his inability to follow through with his own words when he becomes overwhelmed and relies on his agent Ana to make decisions for him.

The film will provide a glimpse into the man’s world by establishing the backstage area as its primary setting, with occasional references to the crowd beyond, although they remain unseen.

The abrupt and ambiguous ending will deprive the audience of closure and avoid providing a clear answer to Fitzroy’s journey. He remains the same character, with unresolved questions and unresolved issues, still avoiding his ex-wife’s calls as the film ends.

There are no easy steps to success here, no surmounting obstacles, no character growth, no answers, just more questions.

thank you.